Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for grey when we want **silence and distance**, or when we are already **too tired of colours**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind a grey stroke

The same grey area on paper can mean **something completely different each time**, depending on what is going on in us. That is why it makes no sense to read a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Calm.

Soft grey areas without sharp edges. A wish that nothing demand attention.

Mist.

Light translucent layers that blend together. Something that does not want to show itself yet.

Stone.

Dense darker strokes, often at the bottom beneath the other colours. A firmness that nothing upsets.

Distance.

Grey between two coloured areas. A space that separates and at the same time protects.

Tiredness.

Dull grey areas without light. A feeling that there has been enough.

Elegance.

Soft transitions from light to dark, precise lines. Joy in simplicity.

Grey in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. A grey picture need not be a sad picture. You can find in it mist, stone, softness, silence or strength. Also tiredness or emptiness. From the amount of grey one cannot tell whether you are sad or "blocked". Equally it can simply be **the colour that was at hand**.

When painting you do not have to look for an explanation. Let your hand work. You can return to what appeared later. It gains meaning only in connection with **your experience**.

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I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A picture and a dress ask two completely different things of you. Perhaps you chose a grey coat because "nobody will comment on that one at least". If nobody were judging me in it, would I choose the same? The answer may well be yes. **Grey need not be questioned just because it is not conspicuous.**

If you like wearing it but do not want to blend in, you do not need to discard half your wardrobe. Try one change. Add to a grey base bigger earrings, a rich scarf or coloured shoes. Combine light and dark, smooth and textured material. Others also notice your voice, movement, expression and way of dealing with people.

Grey will not take your words from you. But a coloured scarf will not start a conversation for you either.

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When grey takes over the space

First, let your hand work. **A grey picture does not have to be cheered up by anyone.** Who actually decided that a picture needs extra colour? Before you reach for yellow, try to notice whether you want it. Or whether you are just now correcting the picture according to someone else's idea of how joy should look.

Three things worth noticing

- **QUANTITY**

Relief, or loss?

A large grey area can pleasantly tie a picture together. At other times it starts to cover everything that was alive in it. Perhaps it is just covering that you want to try and you need not rescue the picture with colour at once. When you want, notice whether you feel good in that area, or feel like making a gap or opening a space.

- **LIGHTNESS**

Mist, or a concrete wall?

A light translucent grey feels different from a dense anthracite. The difference is made by the shade, the amount of paint and the way it is applied. When everything blends for you, try a lighter and a darker grey side by side. When it feels cold, hold ochre, a warm pink or brown against it and compare the impression.

- **THICKNESS**

Painting can be alive even without bright colours

A thin layer can let something show through. A dense one you can press down, push aside or scratch a mark into. If you want something new to appear, let the ground show through or add a colour that attracts you.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a grey stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One arose in a feeling of calm, the other after a day when you wanted to hide. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

After a time you may see that grey gave you calm then. Or it will recall a period when you wanted to hide. In self-reflection inspired by art therapy you link a picture with your own memories. The colour alone will not tell the story for you.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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